

THE FRENCH CHEF IN AN ITALIAN KITCHEN

The thing about being the outsider is that nobody has to say it.

You just know.

It's in the way conversations pause half a beat when you walk into the cool room. The way jokes land and everyone laughs in sync, like they've rehearsed it except you. Not because you didn't get it, but because you weren't meant to. The way "this guy" gets muttered just loud enough for you to catch but quiet enough to deny.

I'd left a CDC position at a modern bistro, hundred and fifty covers, double sittings, fifteen-plus staff under me, a beast by any definition, to take a pay cut and drop a couple of rungs to CDP at a fine dining Italian place in Melbourne. On paper, it looked like career suicide. In my head, it was the only move that made sense.

You can run a kitchen for years and still not know shit.

I knew French. Classical technique, mother sauces, the whole architecture of it burned into my muscle memory. But Italian? Real Italian not the bastardised stuff that gets passed off in suburban trattorias? That was a different language. And I wanted to learn it badly enough to swallow my pride, take the demotion, and start again.

The job was pasta section. Ballsy choice, looking back. Everything made in house, pasta its own section on the menu, and while I'd made pasta before, I'd made it in French kitchens. As I was about to find out, that didn't count for much when it came to authentic ingredient pairing, technique, or execution.

But I was confident. Fast learner. Just left a joint that would've eaten most cooks alive.

How hard could it be.

Right.

What I didn't account for was how small that kitchen would feel. Four cooks in a space the size of a jail cell, and three of them had been working together for years. They moved like one organism—finishing each other's

sentences, anticipating each other's calls, laughing at references I'd never understand.

I was the French chef in an Italian kitchen.

I had more drive and overall kitchen experience than even the Head Chef. But I kept that underplayed. Buried. Because the last thing I needed was to be outcast from the clique even more than I already was.

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The pork belly thing happened about six weeks in.

I was prepping for service, my section boxed and ready to go, when Joe—the Head Chef—asked me to prep the belly for the next day's confit.

Simple enough. I'd done confit more times than I could count. Duck, pork, rabbit, goose—if it had fat and patience, I'd slow-cooked it.

I started looking for the cure mix. Salt, sugar, aromatics—standard stuff. Every kitchen I'd ever worked in had it prepped in bulk, sitting in a cambro somewhere obvious.

Couldn't find it.

I wandered the jail-cell-sized kitchen for a few minutes, checking shelves, corners, the spots where things get shoved and forgotten. Nothing.

Matt—the Sous, and the previous CDP of pasta before I'd filled the position—found me mid-search.

"You lost or just trying to find a way out?"

Laughter from the rest of the brigade. In sync. Rehearsed.

I had to retaliate. It was the only way I wasn't going to get eaten alive and have the day be another mental struggle.

"Nope. Just looking for the cure mix for the pork belly. Something I figured would be prepped in bulk, but I guess that's why you guys need help with your section and mine is boxed, ay."

His smirk flickered. The laughter stopped.

"We brine the belly," he said, less cocky now. "Recipe's in the folder."

"Too easy. Let me know if you need anything else done before service."

Deeply sarcastic. Rooted in a *fuck you, cunt* tone whilst teetering on the line of respect required by hierarchy.

I came very close to cleaning mats that night and it being my last shift.

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After making the brine and letting it cool, I stood over the rare breed belly, fennel-infused liquid ready to go, and had a lightbulb moment.

A lesson taught early on. Widely known regardless of professional or not.

You do not mix water and fat.

Brine adds moisture. Cure removes it. And since I was confiting this thing overnight—submerging it in hot rendered fat—the physics were simple. Moisture trapped in meat plus searing fat equals explosion. Pop. Spit. The kind of violence that ends shifts early and leaves scars.

I put the question out there.

"Question—you want me to brine the belly and then confit it?"

Matt's response was immediate. Not even looking at me.

"Seriously... this guy."

I gave the warranted reason.

"Seems like a bad choice to brine something then confit it. You're adding moisture, not removing it like a cure. That fat's going to pop when it heats. Could explode."

"Just brine the fucking belly. It's how it's done here."

I held his eyes for a second longer than comfortable.

Then I brined the belly.

Not my house. Not my rules.

But I knew—somewhere in the back of my skull, with absolute certainty—that this was going to bite someone eventually.

I just didn't know it'd be Chef's eye.

* * *

Saturday night pre-theatre is a particular kind of violence.

First sitting hits at six. They want three courses in ninety minutes because the curtain waits for no risotto. The mad exodus starts around seven-thirty—tables practically sprinting out the door to their shows—and by then the docket machine is already becoming a demonic overlord, ready and willing to take the souls of anyone who isn't ready and on form.

The rail was loaded.

Matt was on larder and cold entrées with the apprentice—a young guy named Adam, though everyone called him Racina. Acted like an old man

and was wiser than his age by decades despite being barely nineteen. I had pasta. Joe and his missus Rachael were on mains and plating.

Rachael was also CDP, though not really warranted of the position. She assisted in plating for both mains and occasionally pasta—when I gave her the chance, of course.

Chef called dockets as expected. The rhythm locked in. Bodies moving in that tight choreography where you stop thinking and just become the station.

"Three tasting, two à la carte on six."

"Yes, Chef."

"How long on the agnolotti?"

"Two minutes, Chef."

"Behind."

"Hot."

An order came through with one pork belly.

I watched Joe pull it from the lowboy. Watched him slide it onto a tray. Watched him reach up—up, because the salamander in that kitchen was mounted at head height—and slide it onto the bottom shelf.

I cringed.

Same as I always cringed when he did this. Knowing it was brined. Knowing it was at eye level. Knowing exactly what could happen.

But it was one of those situations. Not my house. Not my rules. Shut up and do your job.

By eight o'clock we were fully loaded on all stations. The second wave had hit. The rail was deep.

Then—simultaneously, as Chef turned around—the belly popped.

The sound cut through service noise. Sharp. Violent.

Searing fat sprayed out from under the salamander and caught Joe across the left side of his face.

Eye.

Cheek.

The soft parts that don't forgive.

Everyone froze.

That's the thing about a real emergency—the silence is louder than the chaos. One second the printer's screaming, pans are crashing, five conversations happening at once. The next, nothing. Just the hiss of the salamander and Chef on one knee, hand pressed to his face, swearing.

Scotty—the FOH manager, a hospo veteran who'd been doing this longer than most of us had been alive—pushed through the swing door.

"What do you need, Chef?"

Joe was just swearing. Holding his eye.

Scotty didn't wait for an answer. He grabbed his keys and handed them to the closest food runner — Dylan.

"I'm parked in the Chinatown laneway. Go get my car and take Chef to A&E."

And that's exactly what happened.

But now who was the captain of our about-to-sink ship?

Well. That would be Matt. The Sous Chef.

Except Matt had never run a Saturday night service. He'd only done early weekday nights—cruisy twenty-five to thirty covers, nicely spread. Not sixty to eighty covers for three courses in three hours after being fisted by a pre-theatre sitting.

I looked at him.

He was pale. Actually pale. The colour you go when your brain is running calculations it doesn't like the answers to.

I found joy in the moment.

Just a flash of it—petty, unprofessional, deeply human. Six weeks of "this guy" and cure mix lectures and in-sync laughter, and here he was. Frozen.

"Looks like you're up, Chef."

All the while, tables are still being called away. Every second that passes is an eternity in a kitchen.

"But... but... I—"

The only barely audible words that came from the Sous's mouth.

"For fuck's sake, I'll do it then."

I laughed. Actually laughed.

Scotty had reappeared—must've handed Joe off to Dylan and come straight back. He caught my eye across the line.

"You got this, mate?"

"Does the Pope touch little boys?"

"Good man."

He turned away to work his magic and buy me a couple of minutes in the dining room.

* * *

I grabbed the next docket as I assessed the state of everything in motion.

Then I proceeded to do what I did best. The thing I loved most about being a chef.

Lead service.

And just to boot, I continued to cook and plate my own section at the same time.

"Two agnolotti, one pappardelle, mains to follow in four."

"Yes, Chef."

"Matt, how long on the burrata?"

"Thirty seconds."

"Make it twenty. Table eight's been waiting."

"Yes, Chef."

The rhythm came back. Different now—tighter, more deliberate, running through me instead of around me. I could feel the kitchen settling, finding its feet, trusting that someone was steering.

Rachael's hands stopped shaking around the forty-minute mark. Matt found his timing. Even Raj—the silent Nepalese dishie I'd never heard speak—started anticipating my calls, running pans back before I had to ask.

The night went without a hitch.

Not a single complaint. Not one remake. Not one diner aware of the close-to-complete nuclear-grade meltdown that almost occurred in the kitchen.

Just pure orchestrated success.

* * *

The last ticket went out and Scotty came into the kitchen—which was oddly silent—with a round of Peronis. The staple knock-offs in this particular kitchen.

He handed one to Matt. One to Rachael. Then pressed an extra into my hands.

"Well deserved, Chef. Thank you."

"Here to help. That's what I do."

I said it with a cheeky smirk. Couldn't help myself.

We filed out into the back laneway for some fresh air and quick respite.

There were two other fine dining restaurants in the block that shared the same internal laneway—another Italian and a street-hawker-style joint. On a normal night, there'd be banter between crews, competitive

shit-talk, the kind of solidarity that only exists at midnight between people who've just survived the same war.

Tonight, it was quiet.

I never spoke much anyway—not exactly the social type outside the kitchen. But tonight the others just sat there in silence too.

I broke it.

Poorly placed. A shiv of *I told you so*.

"I've got a good recipe for cure mix if you want to change from brine."

Crickets.

"Too soon then, I guess."

The food runner got back a few minutes later with Joe in tow. Chef was bandaged up, one eye covered. Looked like he'd done three rounds with a deep fryer. The doctors wanted him back in two days to check for damage.

Racina—still out in the laneway with us, probably processing everything he'd just witnessed—turned to me.

"When did you learn to run service, Chef?"

I took a long pull on my beer.

"Been running kitchens for years, bruva. Could do it with my eyes closed."

Silence again. Different this time.

Matt looked up.

"You never mentioned that before."

"You never asked."

I let that land.

"In fact, I'm barely part of the team most days."

It was acknowledged. Not in words—just a quiet exchange of looks in my peripheral as I sank my second beer.

The moment stretched.

Then I pushed off the wall.

"Come on. Let's go—we've got a kitchen to clean."

Everyone jumped up.

"Yes, Chef."

I bumped shoulders with Matt as we walked in.

"You wanna take over yet, or you happy with me to finish up?"

"Go for it. It's all yours."

* * *

Chef was off for just over three weeks.

Matt and I shared the kitchen leadership. I ran the weekends—the ones that could go sideways fast, the ones where you needed someone who'd seen worse and kept moving. During the week, I helped him find the path he wasn't being given under Joe. The development he should've had years ago.

I still wasn't part of the family.

But I was definitely part of the team.

And there was a lot more respect.